A SMART MONEY PLAYBOOK

MONEY HACK

17 Smart Ways to Save Money and Spend It Wisely



ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

SAVE SMARTER · SPEND WITH PURPOSE · KEEP MORE · LIVE BETTER

COPYRIGHT

MONEY HACK

17 Smart Ways to Save Money — and Spend It Wisely

© 2026 Zirlandia Milkovic. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording or otherwise, without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in reviews and for personal use of the worksheets by the purchaser.

First edition, 2026.

FINANCIAL DISCLAIMER

This book is published for **general educational purposes only.** It does not constitute personalised financial, investment, tax, legal or accounting advice, and it does not recommend any specific investment, financial product or provider. Nothing in this book is a guarantee of any financial result, saving or outcome.

Personal finances differ enormously between countries, incomes, household sizes, debts, tax situations and personal obligations. Something that works well for one person may be unsuitable for another. Before making significant financial decisions, consider speaking with a qualified professional who can look at your individual circumstances.

All names, people, scenarios and figures in this book are **hypothetical and illustrative.** Amounts are shown in euros for convenience; they are examples, not benchmarks, forecasts or promises. This book contains no statistics. Where prices, rates or rules matter to your decisions, check current information for your own country and provider.

If you use AI tools as described in the AI chapter, do so at your own discretion. Never share passwords, banking credentials, account or card numbers or other confidential information with them, and always check any calculation or suggestion yourself.

CONTENTS

What's inside

INTRODUCTION

The Money Problem Isn't Always How Much You Earn 4

PART ONE · THE 17 MONEY HACKS

01 The 7-Day Spending Reset 7
02 The 24-Hour Rule 9
03 Audit Your Subscriptions 11
04 The Price-Per-Use Test 13
05 Stop Paying for Convenience Automatically 15
06 The Grocery Money Hack 17
07 Negotiate Your Recurring Bills 19
08 The Need / Want / Value Test 21
09 Use a "Fun Money" Budget 23
10 Automate Your Savings 25
11 Build a Mini Emergency Fund 27
12 The 3-Price Rule 29
13 Use the "Annual Cost" Lens 31
14 Create a "No-Spend" Challenge 33
15 The 30-Day Purchase List 35
16 Stop Lifestyle Creep 37
17 Spend Money Where It Matters 39

PART TWO · HOW TO SPEND MONEY WISELY

The Smart Spending Filter 41
The Smart Spending Filter: printable page 42

PART THREE · BUILD YOUR PERSONAL MONEY SYSTEM

The 5-Bucket Money System 44

AI AND MODERN MONEY MANAGEMENT

Your AI Money Assistant 46
10 Practical AI Prompts 47

PART FOUR · THE 30-DAY MONEY MAKEOVER

Thirty days, four weeks, one sustainable system 48

TOOLS AND CLOSING

Your Monthly Money Review 51
Your Money, Your Choices 52

INTRODUCTION

The money problem isn't always how much you earn

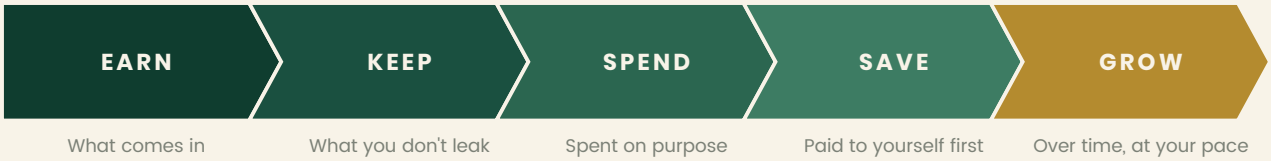
Earn, keep, spend, save, grow.

If you've ever thought, "I'd be fine if I just earned more," this book is for you. Not because earning more is a bad idea, but because it isn't always the first step.

Two people can earn exactly the same salary and end the year in very different places. The difference is rarely intelligence or discipline. It's **awareness, habits and small decisions** made hundreds of times a year, mostly without noticing.

Many people believe that financial wellbeing is a simple matter of income. A higher income certainly helps. But if spending quietly rises to meet every increase, more money changes less than we expect. And if you're already earning reasonably well, the missing ingredient often isn't a bigger paycheque. It's knowing where the money goes.

Think of your financial life as a chain with five links:



Most financial advice lives at either end of the chain: how to **earn** more, or how to **grow** what you have. This book lives in the middle. It's about the three links most people never examine: what you **keep**, how you **spend** it and what you **save**. Strengthen those, and both ends of the chain get easier.

> *I don't necessarily need to earn more money first. I need to become smarter about the money I already have.*

FOUR MINDSET SHIFTS

The old thought	The smarter thought
"I'll be fine once I earn more."	"I'll be fine once I know where my money goes."
"Budgeting means saying no to everything."	"Budgeting means saying yes on purpose."
"Small amounts don't matter."	"Small amounts repeat, and repeating adds up."
"I'll save whatever is left over."	"I'll save first, automatically, and spend the rest."

FINANCIAL LEAKAGE

Financial leakage is what happens when small, recurring decisions quietly drain money you'd rather have kept.

A leak is rarely dramatic. It's a forgotten subscription, a delivery fee you stopped noticing, a habitual snack, a plan you no longer use. Individually, they're easy to ignore. Together, over twelve months, they can be surprisingly significant. Here are a few hypothetical examples:

Hypothetical leak	How often	Each time	Per year
An app you no longer open	Monthly	€9.99	€119.88
Delivery fee, twice a week	Weekly	€4.00 × 2	€416.00
A daily snack or drink out, 3 days a week	Weekly	€4.50 × 3	€702.00
A gym plan you rarely use	Monthly	€35.00	€420.00
One "why not" impulse buy a month	Monthly	€30.00	€360.00

Not every item in a table like this is a leak. If you love your morning coffee and it makes your day better, it's spending, not leakage. A leak is money that goes out **without you deciding it should,** for something that isn't giving you much back.

Please don't read this as an invitation to guilt. This book is **not about refusing to enjoy life.** It isn't about extreme frugality, tracking every cent forever or giving up everything you like. It's about **spending intentionally.**

THE PRINCIPLE

Spend on what matters.
Cut what doesn't.

EVERY SITUATION IS DIFFERENT

Every household is different. Income, country, taxes, family size, debts and obligations all shape what's realistic, so treat every example in this book as an illustration, not a benchmark. Nothing here promises a particular result. The promise is smaller and more honest: better everyday decisions.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- [ ] Choose a notebook, note app or spreadsheet, and use it just for this book.
- [ ] Decide when you'll read: ten minutes a day is plenty.
- [ ] Promise yourself no judgement. You're gathering information, not passing sentence.
- [ ] Pick one hack to try this week. Only one.
- [ ] Remember: small, sustainable changes beat dramatic ones you abandon.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

How this book works, and what you'll be able to do by the end.

Part One contains **17 Money Hacks**, each built the same way: the problem, why we do it, the hack, how to do it, an example, the potential benefit, the common mistake and a quick action. Each has its own two pages, so you can read one over a coffee and act on it the same day. You don't need to do them all, or in order. Start with #1 and #2, and then follow your curiosity.



BY THE END, YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- Identify where your money is disappearing
- Reduce unnecessary expenses
- Stop impulse purchases
- Lower recurring bills
- Shop more intelligently
- Avoid lifestyle inflation
- Use simple spending rules
- Build an emergency fund
- Automate your savings
- Tell needs from wants
- Spend on what improves your life
- Create a realistic money system

MONEY HACK

#01

The 7-Day Spending Reset

You can't improve what you've never seen.

THE PROBLEM

You reach the end of the month and your balance is lower than you expected. You can't quite say where the money went. That isn't carelessness. Most spending happens in small moments that never feel like decisions: a tap of the card, a renewed plan, a "just this once."

WHY WE DO IT

Our memory holds on to big purchases and forgets the dozens of small ones. Paying by phone or card removes the physical feedback of handing money over, so spending feels lighter than it is. And when we suspect the total will be uncomfortable, we tend to avoid looking at all.

THE HACK

For seven days, write down everything you spend, without changing your behaviour, without judging, and without promising to be "better." Awareness comes before optimisation. A week of honest data is worth more than a month of good intentions.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Don't fix anything this week. Just look. A tracker isn't a verdict on you. It's a flashlight.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Pick seven consecutive days that feel fairly normal: not a holiday, not payday week.
2. Capture each purchase when it happens, in a phone note or a photo of the receipt. By evening, memory has already edited the day.
3. Each evening, enter the amounts in the tracker on the next page, using one of six categories.
4. Count recurring charges on the day they leave your account.
5. On day eight, total each column and ask: *What surprised me? What did I forget I pay for? What did I genuinely enjoy?*

> **THE SIX CATEGORIES**
> **Essentials:** housing, groceries, transport, health. **Lifestyle:** planned wants such as dining with friends or hobbies. **Impulse:** unplanned, "saw it, bought it." **Subscriptions:** anything that renews. **Debt:** repayments on cards or loans. **Other:** everything else.

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

Imagine a hypothetical week in which someone spends €212 outside rent and bills. When they sort it, €58 turns out to be Impulse and €31 is two subscriptions they'd forgotten. Nothing dramatic, and no reason for guilt. It's simply the first time the numbers have been visible.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A clear, judgement-free picture of your real spending, which every later hack builds on. Many people also find that the act of noticing makes them pause at impulse moments. Results vary; this week's goal is information, not savings.

COMMON MISTAKE

Logging only the "bad" purchases, or tidying up your behaviour because you're being watched. Log everything, including the awkward items. If you miss a day, note the gap and carry on: a six-day week is still useful.

TRY THIS TODAY

Open your phone's notes app and create a note called "Reset Week." Tomorrow morning, log your first purchase.

HYPOTHETICAL CASE STUDY

Lena and the €150 she didn't know about

Lena, 27, works in marketing and assumed her finances were "fine." After a week of tracking, and a look at her statements, she spotted a streaming plan she never opened, a gym she used twice a month and frequent small delivery orders. Together they added up to roughly **€150 a month, or €1,800 a year.** She kept the gym, cancelled the rest and redirected part of the saving to a new savings account.

Fictional and illustrative. Individual results vary, and none is guaranteed.

YOUR 7-DAY SPENDING TRACKER

DAY	ESSENTIALS (€)	LIFESTYLE (€)	IMPULSE (€)	SUBSCRIPTIONS (€)	DEBT (€)	OTHER (€)
Day 1						
Day 2						
Day 3						
Day 4						
Day 5						
Day 6						
Day 7						
Total						

Write the item beside the amount if you like, but the amount is what matters. Total each column on day eight.

MONEY HACK

#02

The 24-Hour Rule

Between wanting and buying, insert a day.

THE PROBLEM

A notification lights up your phone. A sale ends at midnight. A friend shows off something new. Before you've really thought, the item is in your basket, and by Thursday it's in a drawer.

WHY WE DO IT

Wanting feels urgent because it is a strong emotion, and shops know it. Countdown timers, "only 3 left" banners and one-click checkout are all designed to shorten the gap between desire and payment. Emotions fade quickly, though, and the gap is exactly where your judgement lives.

THE HACK

Put a pause between wanting a non-essential item and paying for it. Do this consistently: **Want → Pause → Reconsider → Decide.** For small purchases, 24 hours is enough. For bigger ones, extend the pause. You're not forbidding yourself anything, only asking the purchase to survive a night's sleep.

WANT	PAUSE	RECONSIDER	DECIDE
Notice the urge without acting	Wait 24 hours (or longer for bigger items)	What is it for? Do I own something similar?	Buy it, skip it or park it

MONEY HACK

If it's still a great idea tomorrow, buy it with a clear head. If it's forgotten by tomorrow, it was never a need.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Decide your threshold: for example, the pause applies to any non-essential purchase above €15.
2. When the urge strikes, move the item to a wishlist or the cart, and close the tab. Don't pay.
3. Write one line: what problem does this solve, or what feeling am I chasing?
4. Come back after 24 hours (a week for anything above €100) and ask again with fresh eyes.
5. If you still want it, buy it without guilt. If not, delete it and notice how that feels.

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

Picture a hypothetical shopper who adds a €89 jacket to their basket at 11pm. The next evening the excitement has gone, and they realise they own two similar jackets. They close the tab. Another day, they add a pair of boots, wait, and still want them the next day. This time they buy them and love them.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Fewer purchases you regret, and more confidence in the ones you make. The rule takes pressure off you: there's no willpower battle, only a delay. Savings depend entirely on what you'd otherwise have bought.

COMMON MISTAKE

Turning the pause into a loophole, such as "I'll just check the price again" while staying in the shop. Leave the page. Also, don't apply it to true essentials such as medicine or a broken fridge.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose your threshold today and write it on a note where you shop online. Then use it on the very next non-essential purchase.

WHAT TO DO DURING THE PAUSE

Type of purchase	Typical trigger	Use the pause to…
Online shopping	Flash sale, "items in your cart" emails	Close the tab. Check whether you already own something similar.
Clothing	A new season, a shop window	Name three outfits it would join. Can't? Wait.
Electronics	Launch hype, upgrade emails	Ask what your current one can't do. Compare options (Hack #12).
Beauty products	Recommendations, "bundle" offers	Check what's half-used at home first.
Other extras	Boredom, a hard day, social pressure	Name the feeling. Do something free for 20 minutes.

HYPOTHETICAL CASE STUDY

Daniel and the evening scroll

Daniel shops online most evenings "just to look." He adopts a 24-hour rule and parks items in the basket overnight. After a few weeks, he notices that most items don't survive the pause, and the ones that do feel better bought. His Impulse column shrinks, not through force, but because the urge is given time to fade.

Fictional and illustrative. Individual results vary, and none is guaranteed.

MONEY HACK

#03

Audit Your Subscriptions

The cheapest expense to remove is the one you forgot about.



THE PROBLEM

Streaming, apps, cloud storage, memberships, free trials that quietly turned paid: each one is small, so none of them hurts. Together they can become a substantial monthly total that most of us couldn't recite from memory.

WHY WE DO IT

Subscriptions are built on inertia. Signing up takes one tap; cancelling takes effort, and we rarely feel the charge. Free trials assume you'll forget. And because each amount looks tiny, the mind files it under "not worth the hassle."

THE HACK

Once, sit down and list every recurring payment, then price each in two ways: per month and per year. **€9.99 a month is €119.88 a year.** Then decide, one by one, whether to keep, cancel or review. An audit takes an hour and can pay off all year.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Ask of each subscription: "If this were an annual bill in front of me, would I sign it today?"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Open your last three bank and card statements. Highlight anything repeating.
2. Check app-store subscriptions, PayPal and other payment services, since they're easy to miss.
3. List each service in the audit table, with the monthly cost and the yearly cost (×12).
4. Note honestly how often you used it in the past month.
5. Mark each **Keep**, **Cancel** or **Review**. Cancel today, and set a calendar reminder to revisit the Review items in 30 days.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU SUBSCRIBE**
> Is there a free or cheaper version? Will I still use this in three months? On what date does this trial end?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical list might show a streaming service (€12.99/month), a music app (€10.99), a cloud-storage plan (€2.99) and a meditation app (€9.99). That's €36.96 a month, or **€443.52 a year**. If the meditation app hasn't been opened since spring and the cloud plan is only half used, the choices become easy.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Lower fixed costs without any daily effort: cancel once and you save every month after. You also gain the reassurance of knowing exactly what leaves your account.

COMMON MISTAKE

Cancelling everything in a burst of enthusiasm and then re-subscribing to half of it. Keep what you truly use and enjoy. The goal isn't fewer subscriptions; it's subscriptions you'd choose again.

TRY THIS TODAY

Set a reminder for the first of each month: "Check subscriptions, 5 minutes." And mark any free trial's end date the day you start it.

THE SUBSCRIPTION AUDIT

SERVICE	MONTHLY COST (€)	ANNUAL COST (€, ×12)	HOW OFTEN USED	KEEP / CANCEL / REVIEW
Totals				

Where to look: bank and card statements, app-store subscriptions, PayPal and similar services, email receipts (search for "renewal" or "subscription"), and your phone's subscription settings.

MONEY HACK

#04

The Price-Per-Use Test

The sticker price is only the beginning of the story.

THE PROBLEM

We compare prices at the till, but what we're really buying is *use*. A cheap item worn twice is expensive. A costly item used every day can be a bargain. Shopping by sticker price alone gets both wrong.

WHY WE DO IT

The price tag is vivid and immediate, while future use is vague and easy to overestimate. Sales make it worse: "40% off" feels like a win even when the item wouldn't have been bought at full price, or won't be used at the discounted one.

THE HACK

Before buying, estimate how many times you'll realistically use the item, then divide.

PRICE what you pay ÷ **EXPECTED USES** honest, realistic = **COST PER USE** what it really costs

MONEY HACK

A lower price per use does not automatically justify a purchase. It only shows whether the purchase is likely to earn its place.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Write down the price, including delivery or accessories.
2. Estimate realistic uses, based on your habits and not your best intentions. If you've never used a similar item, halve your first guess.
3. Divide the price by the uses to get the cost per use.
4. Compare it against alternatives, including the option of not buying.
5. Ask whether the item is better value at a higher price if it lasts longer or is more comfortable to use.

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A €180 winter coat worn 120 times costs €1.50 per wear. A €25 top worn four times costs €6.25 per wear. A €40 monthly gym membership used 24 times a year comes to €480 ÷ 24 = €20 per visit. The same membership used 96 times costs €5 per visit. These are hypothetical figures, but the pattern is the point.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A steadier way to judge value across clothing, kitchen equipment, technology, travel and entertainment. It also shows when paying more makes sense: for things you'll use often, that last, or that make daily life easier.

COMMON MISTAKE

Inflating the uses to justify the purchase. Also, using it as a licence: a low cost per use still means spending money you may not need to spend. It's a test, not a permission slip.

TRY THIS TODAY

Pick one item you're considering this month. Calculate its cost per use, and give yourself an honest number of uses.

SIX HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLES

Item (hypothetical)	Price	Realistic uses	Cost per use
Winter coat	€180	120 wears	€1.50
Trend-driven top	€25	4 wears	€6.25
Gym membership, used 24 times a year	€480 / year	24 visits	€20.00
The same membership, used 96 times	€480 / year	96 visits	€5.00
Stand mixer	€260	100 uses	€2.60
Streaming plan	€144 / year	60 viewing sessions	€2.40
Good headphones	€120	600 hours	€0.20 per hour
Weekend trip	€420	3 days	€140 per day, judged on memories, not maths

PAYING MORE CAN BE SMART WHEN…

the item is used often, is built to last or be repaired, affects your health, comfort or safety, or comes with a strong warranty. Paying more is *not* smart when it's rarely used, when you're buying a name or when the extra features would never be touched.

YOUR TURN

ITEM I'M CONSIDERING	PRICE (€)	HONEST NUMBER OF USES	COST PER USE (€)

MONEY HACK

#05

Stop Paying for Convenience Automatically

Convenience is a real service. Just choose when to buy it.

THE PROBLEM

Delivery fees, express shipping, ride-hailing, takeaway when the fridge is full, the convenience store on the way home: each is reasonable on its own. But a habit of paying a premium to skip small frictions can become one of the least noticeable costs in a budget.

WHY WE DO IT

Convenience wins when we're tired, rushed or short of planning. The extra cost is small compared with the effort saved in that moment, so we say yes. Repeat that choice daily, and it becomes the default without ever being decided.

THE HACK

Separate **valuable convenience** from **expensive habit**. Paying to save time you'd truly use, or to solve a real constraint, is often money well spent. Paying out of tiredness, poor planning or autopilot is a habit. The aim isn't to remove convenience. It's to choose it.

> **MONEY HACK**
> The question isn't "Is this convenient?" It's "Is this convenience worth its premium, today?"

HOW TO DO IT

1. For one week, mark each purchase where you paid extra to save time, effort or planning.
2. Next to each, write the extra cost, meaning the fee or the price difference, not the whole price.
3. Apply the three-question test below to each entry.
4. Keep the conveniences that pass. For the habits, find the smallest fix: plan ahead, batch orders, or add a default.
5. Set rules you can live with, such as "delivery on Fridays only" or "one ride-hail a week."

> **THINK BEFORE YOU TAP**
> Could I have planned this an hour ago? What am I paying for the shortcut? Would I pay this fee if I had to hand it over in cash?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

Suppose someone pays a €4.50 delivery fee three times a week, out of habit, not need. That's about €13.50 weekly, or roughly €700 a year (hypothetical). Moving two of those orders into a planned weekly shop, and keeping one delivery for a busy day, removes most of the cost and keeps the benefit.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Lower spending on the choices that give you the least, while keeping the ones that give you time or ease. Many people find they enjoy convenience more once it's deliberate.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating convenience as a moral failing. If a fee gives you back an evening with your family, that may be excellent value. Judge by what it buys, not by how it feels to pay.

TRY THIS TODAY

Next time you're about to add a delivery, express or ride-hail charge, ask the three questions below before you tap.

TWO KINDS OF CONVENIENCE

Valuable convenience	Expensive habit
Buys back time you'll really use	Fills a moment of tiredness or boredom
Solves a real constraint: illness, no car, heavy loads	Solves a planning gap you could easily fix
The premium is small next to the benefit	The premium is larger than the benefit
Chosen on purpose	Happens on autopilot

THE THREE-QUESTION TEST

1. Will I really use the time or effort this saves?
2. Is this a genuine constraint, or a planning gap I could fix?
3. Is the extra cost proportionate to what I get in return?

YOUR CONVENIENCE LOG

THE CONVENIENCE	EXTRA COST (€)	WHAT DID IT BUY ME?	WORTH IT? (Y / N)

MONEY HACK

#06

The Grocery Money Hack

Plan the shop, and the shop stops planning you.



THE PROBLEM

Groceries are a large, flexible part of most households' spending. They're also where unplanned extras, duplicates and food that goes off unnoticed can build up week after week.

WHY WE DO IT

Shopping without a plan leaves decisions to the shelf layout. Hunger, tiredness and "bargain" labels push us to add things we didn't need, and we forget what's already at home. Food waste isn't laziness. It's usually a planning gap.

THE HACK

Run groceries as a small weekly system: check what you have, plan meals around it, shop from a list, compare unit prices, and use it all before buying more.

> **MONEY HACK**
> The cheapest food is the food you already own. Start every shop at your own fridge.

HOW TO DO IT

1. **Use what you have.** Note perishables that need eating soon, and build meals around them.
2. **Plan 4 to 5 dinners** with flexible slots. Leave room for leftovers and a spontaneous night.
3. **Write the list** by supermarket section, and stick to it.
4. **Compare unit prices** (per kg, per litre, per 100 g). Bigger isn't always cheaper.
5. **Buy in bulk only** what you reliably use and can store: rice, pasta, tins, freezer items. Not perishables you can't finish.
6. **Reduce waste:** store food properly, freeze extras, and give leftovers a planned night.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU BULK-BUY**
> Will we finish it before it expires? Do I have space to store it? Is the unit price genuinely lower?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A 500 g pack at €1.80 costs €3.60 per kg. A 1.5 kg pack at €4.50 costs €3.00 per kg. Cheaper per kg, but only if you'll use it all. Hypothetical figures; check your own shelves.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Fewer impulse extras, less food thrown away and calmer weeknights. Savings vary widely by household, store and region.

COMMON MISTAKE

Going extreme: rigid meal plans that you abandon by Wednesday. Build flexibility in. Also, avoid shopping hungry, since a snack before you go is the cheapest trick in this chapter.

TRY THIS TODAY

Before your next shop, photograph your fridge and pantry. Plan two meals around what's already there.

THE 7-DAY SMART GROCERY PLAN

Day	Focus	What to do
1	Check	Look through fridge, freezer and pantry. Note what needs using soon.
2	Plan	Pick 4 to 5 dinners using what you have. Add one leftovers night and one flexible night.
3	List	Write your list by supermarket section. Cross-check against your pantry.
4	Compare	Check unit prices (per kg, litre or 100 g) and store-brand options for staples.
5	Shop	Go after a snack, with your list. Skip the aisles you don't need.
6	Prep	Wash, chop, portion and freeze. Label with dates.
7	Use it up	Make one clear-out meal from odds and ends. Note what was wasted.

BEFORE YOU SHOP

- [ ] I checked my fridge, freezer and pantry
- [ ] I have 4 to 5 meals planned, plus one spare night
- [ ] My list is written by section
- [ ] I've had something to eat before shopping

UNIT-PRICE CHECK

PRODUCT	PRICE (€)	AMOUNT	PER KG / L

MONEY HACK

#07

Negotiate Your Recurring Bills

A five-minute conversation can be worth a year of small savings.



THE PROBLEM

Internet, mobile phone, insurance, bank fees, software, memberships: these bills renew quietly, often at prices set years ago. Most of us never look at them again after signing up.

WHY WE DO IT

Comparing providers feels tedious, and calling a helpline feels awkward. So we stay put, and loyalty can quietly cost more than a new customer would pay. Companies know that most people don't ask.

THE HACK

Once or twice a year, review each recurring bill with three questions: **"What am I paying? What alternatives exist? Can this cost be reduced?"** Not every bill is negotiable, and some can't be lowered at all. But asking is free, and even a no gives you information.

> **MONEY HACK**
> You're not begging for a favour. You're a customer checking whether the price still matches the service.

HOW TO DO IT

1. List your recurring bills, with the current monthly price and the contract end date.
2. Check what you actually use: data, speed, coverage, extras you never touch.
3. Look at current offers from other providers, including what new customers are offered. Compare like with like.
4. Contact your provider. Be polite, be specific, and ask: *"I've seen a comparable plan for €X. Is there anything you can do on my current price or plan?"*
5. Ask about lower tiers, removing add-ons and loyalty options. If they can't help, consider switching, after checking notice periods and exit fees.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU SWITCH**
> Are there exit fees or a minimum term? Does the new price stay fixed, or rise after a year? Is the service truly comparable?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical household discovers its internet plan is €15 a month higher than a comparable current offer. A short call leads to a lower tier for €8 less. Nothing dramatic, but €96 a year for ten minutes. Another bill has no room to move, and they leave it alone.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Lower fixed costs when a bill has room to move, and clearer knowledge of what you pay for when it doesn't. Outcomes depend on the provider, the contract and the market where you live.

COMMON MISTAKE

Assuming every bill can be reduced, or switching without reading the terms. Check minimum contract periods and fees first. A cheaper price isn't a saving if a penalty cancels it out.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose the one bill you haven't looked at in over a year. Write down what you pay and look up one alternative today.

HYPOTHETICAL CASE STUDY

Ana and Tomás hold a "bills evening"

Ana and Tomás share a home and a budget. One evening, they listed their recurring costs, compared two providers and made two calls. One company offered a cheaper tier; the other couldn't help, so they left it alone. They also merged two overlapping streaming plans into one. They agreed to repeat the exercise each January.

Fictional and illustrative. Individual results vary, and none is guaranteed.

THE THREE QUESTIONS

1. What am I paying?
Find the exact monthly price, the contract end date and what's included.

2. What alternatives exist?
Look at comparable current offers from at least two other providers.

3. Can this cost be reduced?
Ask about a cheaper plan, a discount or removing extras you don't use.

YOUR BILL REVIEW

BILL	NOW (€ / MONTH)	BETTER OFFER (€)	ASKED? (Y / N)	OUTCOME

Bills worth reviewing: Internet · Mobile phone · Insurance · Bank fees · Software · Memberships

MONEY HACK

#08

The Need / Want / Value Test

Three questions that replace guilt with clarity.

THE PROBLEM

Most spending advice sorts things into “needs” and “wants” and stops there. In real life the line blurs. A phone is a need, but the newest model may not be. A gym can be health or a habit you don’t use.

WHY WE DO IT

Emotion makes everything sound like a need in the moment. “I need new trainers” often means “I want something new.” Yet a strict ban on wants is unrealistic, and sooner or later it collapses.

THE HACK

Add a third question that most people skip: **value.** Before a purchase, ask **Do I need it? Do I want it? Does it provide enough value for its cost?** A want with high value can be a smart buy. A need at an inflated price may still deserve a second look.

DO I NEED IT?	DO I WANT IT?	IS IT WORTH ITS COST?
Would something important suffer without it?	Is this honest enjoyment? Wants are allowed.	Given use and lifespan, is this a fair price for me?

> **MONEY HACK**
> A need can still be overpriced. A want can still be worth it. Value is the referee.

HOW TO DO IT

1. **Need:** Would something important stop working or suffer without it?
2. **Want:** Is this about enjoyment, comfort or identity? Wants are allowed. Just name them honestly.
3. **Value:** Given how often I’ll use it and how long it lasts, is the cost fair *for me*?
4. Decide: buy, wait (Hack #2), find a cheaper way to meet the need, or let it go.
5. Use the worksheet on the next page for bigger purchases.

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical shopper tests three items. Boots to replace leaking ones: need yes, want yes, value good, so buy. A third pair of white trainers: need no, want yes, value low, so wait. Noise-cancelling headphones for a loud commute: need partly, want yes, value good, so buy or plan for it.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A calm, repeatable way to say yes and no. It prevents emotional purchases without asking you to live on rice and hope, because good wants are allowed to pass.

COMMON MISTAKE

Answering “yes” to all three because you already want the thing. Try answering as if advising a friend. And don’t skip the value question: it’s the one that does the real work.

TRY THIS TODAY

Apply the three questions to the last non-essential thing you bought. What would you do differently?

WORKED EXAMPLES (HYPOTHETICAL)

Item (hypothetical)	Need?	Want?	Value?	Decision
Boots to replace leaking ones	Yes	Yes	Good	Buy
A third pair of white trainers	No	Yes	Low	Wait 30 days
Noise-cancelling headphones for a loud commute	Partly	Yes	Good	Buy, or plan for it

PURCHASE DECISION WORKSHEET

ITEM	PRICE (€)	NEED? Y / N	WANT? Y / N	VALUE 1–5	BUY / WAIT / SKIP

Suppose I couldn't buy it. What would I do instead?

MONEY HACK

#09

Use a “Fun Money” Budget

A plan you can enjoy is a plan you can keep.



THE PROBLEM

Many budgets fail not because people are undisciplined, but because they leave no room for joy. When every euro must justify itself, ordinary life starts to feel like punishment, and the whole plan gets abandoned.

WHY WE DO IT

Strict cutting builds pressure. Sooner or later, that pressure releases in a large, guilty splurge that undoes weeks of effort. Enjoyment isn’t the enemy of a financial plan. Unplanned enjoyment is.

THE HACK

Set aside a defined amount each month that is **explicitly yours to spend on anything you enjoy**, with no justification and no guilt. This is **the guilt-free spending account.** Everything else in your plan can then be more serious, because this part isn’t.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Guilt-free means you decided in advance. The plan already approved this spending.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Decide an amount you can sustain, small enough to be responsible and large enough to matter. Percentages are a fair starting point.
2. Keep it separate: a second account, a sub-account, a prepaid card or a labelled cash envelope.
3. Move the money at the start of the month, ideally right after payday.
4. Spend it freely: coffee, books, dinners, games, gifts. No explaining.
5. When it’s gone, it’s gone. If there’s some left, decide whether it rolls over or goes to savings.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU SET THE AMOUNT**
> Is this sustainable in a tight month? Will it feel generous without feeling reckless? Would I resent the number in three months?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical couple sets aside €80 each per month. One spends theirs on concerts, the other on climbing sessions. Because it's agreed and separate, there's no commentary on how it's used, and far less friction about everything else.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A more realistic plan and fewer "screw it" splurges. For couples, it can reduce arguments, since each person has autonomy inside the shared budget.

COMMON MISTAKE

Making it so small that it feels like a joke, or so large that it swallows your savings. Adjust after two or three months. Also, don't use it for essentials; it's for fun.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose your monthly fun amount now and open or label a place to keep it. Give it a name you like.

SET UP YOUR GUILT-FREE SPENDING ACCOUNT

Monthly fun amount (€)

Where it lives (account, card, envelope)

It moves over on (date)

If there's money left, it…

This month, my fun money is for…

SETUP CHECKLIST

- [ ] I chose an amount I can keep up every month
- [ ] It lives in a separate account, card or envelope
- [ ] It moves over right after payday
- [ ] I've told my partner or household, if it applies
- [ ] I've agreed: when it's spent, it's spent

MONEY HACK

#10

Automate Your Savings

The best savings habit is the one you never have to remember.



THE PROBLEM

Saving "what's left" at the end of the month tends to fail, because by then very little is left. Good intentions meet a busy life, and the money finds a use.

WHY WE DO IT

Willpower is a limited resource, and decisions repeated monthly wear it down. Money sitting in your everyday account feels available, so it's spent. Out of sight really can mean out of mind.

THE HACK

Pay yourself first. Set an automatic transfer to a separate savings account on payday, before you have a chance to spend. Choose an amount or percentage that fits *your* situation. There's no universal ideal number. A small amount that continues beats a big plan that stops.

> **MONEY HACK**
> You don't need to decide to save every month. You decided once.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Look at your last few months to find a comfortable amount you could move without strain.
2. Express it as a percentage of income or a fixed sum. Percentages adjust as income changes.
3. Open a separate savings account and name it after its goal.
4. Set a standing order for the day after payday.
5. Review after three months, and nudge the amount up when you can, even by a little.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU AUTOMATE**
> Will this transfer leave enough for bills in the week after payday? Which account will hold it? Have I named what it's for?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

These are illustrative only. On a hypothetical monthly take-home of €1,800: 3% is €54, 5% is €90 and 10% is €180. Over twelve months, that's €648, €1,080 or €2,160, before any interest. Your right figure may be lower or higher. Start where you can stay.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

More consistent saving without daily effort. Automation also protects you from your own mood: the transfer happens whether you feel motivated or not.

COMMON MISTAKE

Choosing an amount so ambitious that you have to switch it off after two months. If you have to pause, lower it rather than stop. And remember: an automated transfer can't help if your account can't cover it.

TRY THIS TODAY

Log in to your banking app and schedule one small transfer for the day after your next payday.

HYPOTHETICAL CASE STUDY

Mia and the unpredictable income

Mia is a freelance designer whose income swings from month to month. Instead of a fixed transfer, she moves a **percentage of each payment** the day it arrives: one share to a tax-and-bills account and a smaller share to savings. In lean months the transfers are small; in strong months, larger. She also knows her "baseline month": the minimum she needs to cover essentials. (*Tax rules vary by country, so she checks the local requirements.*)

Fictional and illustrative. Individual results vary, and none is guaranteed.

THE AUTOMATIC SAVINGS SETUP

My monthly take-home (€)

Percentage or amount to save

From account

To account (give it a name)

Payday

Transfer date

- [ ] I chose an amount or percentage I can sustain
- [ ] I opened a separate account and gave it a name
- [ ] The transfer is set for the day after payday
- [ ] I checked that the amount won't overdraw me
- [ ] I set a reminder to review in three months

WHAT DIFFERENT PERCENTAGES LOOK LIKE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Share of monthly take-home	€1,200	€1,800	€2,400
3%	€36 (€432 a year)	€54 (€648 a year)	€72 (€864 a year)
5%	€60 (€720 a year)	€90 (€1,080 a year)	€120 (€1,440 a year)
10%	€120 (€1,440 a year)	€180 (€2,160 a year)	€240 (€2,880 a year)

MONEY HACK

#11

Build a Mini Emergency Fund

A small cushion turns a crisis into an inconvenience.



THE PROBLEM

Life is full of predictable surprises: a car repair, a dental bill, a broken laptop, an urgent trip, a gap between jobs. Without a cushion, a small problem becomes a credit-card balance, and a credit-card balance becomes a bigger problem.

WHY WE DO IT

It's hard to save for something that hasn't happened, and easy to feel that "it won't be me." Big targets feel so far away that many people never start.

THE HACK

Build a **mini emergency fund** in stages. Start with a small first target you can reach within a few weeks, then grow toward a larger cushion based on your circumstances. There isn't one right amount for everyone. It depends on your income stability, dependants, health, housing and obligations.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Your first goal isn't "enough." It's "not starting from zero."

HOW TO DO IT

1. Add up your essential monthly costs: housing, food, transport, utilities, insurance, minimum debt payments.
2. Choose a starter target that feels achievable, such as a few hundred euros or one week of essentials.
3. Open a separate account you don't touch for daily spending, and set up an automatic transfer.
4. When you reach each stage, celebrate, then set the next: for example, one month of essentials, then longer as your situation calls for.
5. Use it only for genuine emergencies, and rebuild it afterwards.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU DIP IN**
> Is this a genuine emergency, or a want in disguise? Could it wait a week? If I use it, what is my plan to refill it?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical person with essentials of €1,400 a month might set stages at €300, then €700 (half a month), then €1,400 (a month), and later a larger cushion. Someone with irregular income or dependants may prefer to aim higher. Someone with very stable circumstances may aim lower. It's your call.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Less stress and fewer forced financial decisions when something goes wrong. A cushion buys you time and options.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating it as a general spending pot, or delaying because the "full" number seems impossible. Also avoid keeping it where it's easy to raid. Some friction is helpful.

TRY THIS TODAY

Work out your essential monthly costs today, and choose your first target number.

YOUR EMERGENCY-FUND LADDER

STAGE	WHAT IT COVERS	MY TARGET (€)	BY WHEN
1. Starter	A first cushion for small surprises		
2. One week	About a week of essential costs		
3. One month	About a month of essential costs		
4. Longer cushion	Sized to your income, dependants and health		

WHAT COUNTS AS AN EMERGENCY?

A genuine emergency	Not an emergency (plan for it)
A repair that stops daily life: car, boiler, fridge	A sale or a "deal"
Medical or dental costs	A holiday, or a weekend away
A temporary drop or gap in income	Birthdays, gifts and seasonal costs
Essential travel, such as family illness	Upgrades or "I deserve it" treats
A sudden household emergency	A cheaper price you'd like to lock in

MONEY HACK

#12

The 3-Price Rule

Compare three before you commit to one.

THE PROBLEM

We often buy the first option we see, or the cheapest, or the one a friend mentioned. For small items that's fine. For a laptop, appliance or piece of furniture, it can be an expensive shortcut.

WHY WE DO IT

Comparing takes effort, and there's a fear of "analysis paralysis." So we either grab the first decent option or endlessly browse. Neither is efficient.

THE HACK

Before a significant purchase, compare **at least three realistic options.** Not fifty. Three is enough to reveal the price range, the trade-offs and what you're really paying for. Then compare on more than price alone: **quality, warranty, features, reviews and long-term value.**

> **MONEY HACK**
> The cheapest option isn't automatically the best value, and neither is the most expensive.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Define what "significant" means for you, for example anything over €100.
2. List what you actually need it to do. Ignore features you'd never use.
3. Find three realistic options across different price points.
4. Fill in the comparison table on the next page, including warranty length and total cost of ownership (running costs, consumables, repairs).
5. Read reviews for patterns, not scores: what do people say after six months?

> **THINK BEFORE YOU BUY THE WINNER**
> Am I choosing this because it's best for me, or because it was the last one I looked at? What would make me regret it in a year?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical shopper compares three vacuum cleaners: a budget model at €90, a mid-range one at €160 with a five-year warranty, and a premium one at €320. The middle option isn't the cheapest, but the warranty and the reviews about durability make it the best fit for their home.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Fewer regrets on big purchases, and a better sense of what's reasonable to pay. Sometimes the comparison shows the cheapest option is fine. Sometimes it shows that it isn't.

COMMON MISTAKE

Comparing forever. Set a deadline: two days for research, then decide. Also, be careful with reviews: they can be biased or out of date, so look for consistent themes.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose one upcoming purchase and find three options for it in the next 20 minutes.

THE 3-PRICE COMPARISON

WHAT I'M COMPARING	OPTION A	OPTION B	OPTION C
Price (€)			
Quality and materials			
Warranty			
Key features I'll really use			
Reviews: what patterns?			
Long-term value and running costs			
Total cost of ownership (€)			

My choice, and why

MONEY HACK

#13

Use the "Annual Cost" Lens

€15 a month sounds small. €180 a year doesn't.

THE PROBLEM

We budget and think in months, and monthly prices are designed to feel small. "Just €15 a month" slips easily past our attention, even though it adds up to a decent weekend away.

WHY WE DO IT

Our minds are poor at multiplying small, repeating amounts. Sellers know this: they quote per month, per week, even per day, because a small number is easier to accept than a large one.

THE HACK

Convert every recurring cost into an **annual number**: **€15 a month = €180 a year.** Then ask what else that amount could do. This isn't about cancelling everything. It's about seeing the true size of your commitments and choosing them knowingly.

> **MONEY HACK**
> A price feels different when you see it the way it actually lands on your year.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Pick your recurring and habitual costs: subscriptions, phone, internet, gym, insurance, regular treats.
2. Write each one as a monthly figure. For weekly habits, multiply by 52 and divide by 12, or just multiply by 52 for the annual figure.
3. Multiply monthly figures by 12.
4. Add up the annual total.
5. Mark the three items that feel most surprising, and ask whether each is still worth it.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU CANCEL**
> What does this cost per use? What would I miss if it vanished tomorrow? Would I choose it again today?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical person spends €4.20 on a daily coffee on 5 workdays. That's €21 a week, or **€1,092 a year**. They might decide it's worth every cent, a genuine daily pleasure. Or they might keep two a week and swap the rest. The point is to choose it deliberately. Annual numbers are a lens, not a verdict.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A more accurate feel for the weight of small commitments, which can make it easier to prioritise. It also helps compare very different expenses on the same scale.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using big annual numbers to feel guilty. The annual lens isn't a judgement, and a €1,000 habit you love may be the best money you spend. Make sure to annualise the things you value too.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose one monthly cost and multiply it by 12. Write the number somewhere you'll see it this week.

WHERE DOES MY MONEY GO EVERY YEAR?

EXPENSE	MONTHLY (€)	× 12 = ANNUAL (€)	WORTH IT? (Y / N / ?)
Streaming and apps			
Phone plan			
Internet			
Gym or fitness			
Coffee and snacks out			
Delivery and convenience fees			
Insurance			
Memberships and software			
Total per year			

For weekly costs, multiply by 52 for the annual figure. Then circle the three numbers that surprise you most.

MONEY HACK

#14

Create a “No-Spend” Challenge

A short pause that makes your habits visible.

THE PROBLEM

Much of our spending runs on autopilot: the coffee, the app purchase, the “quick look” at the shop. It’s hard to notice a habit when you’re inside it.

WHY WE DO IT

We rarely stop spending long enough to see what we reach for. A brief break interrupts the loop and shows which purchases were real needs and which were reflexes.

THE HACK

For **seven days**, spend only on the essentials you’ve defined. The aim is **awareness, not deprivation.** You’re not punishing yourself or proving anything. You’re running an experiment: what do I miss, and what did I never really want?

> **MONEY HACK**
> Notice the urge, name it, and move on. What you observe matters more than what you save.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Pick a week that isn’t full of birthdays, trips or big events.
2. Write down what’s allowed. The essentials are listed on the next page, and you decide the optional extras.
3. Tell the people around you, so you don’t have to negotiate in the moment.
4. Each day, tick off the day and jot down any urge to spend, and what triggered it.
5. At the end, review: what did I miss? What surprised me? What will I keep?

> **THINK BEFORE YOU START**
> Is this a realistic week for me? What’s my plan for the moments I usually spend? Who can help me stay on track?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical participant notices on day two that most of their urges come at 4pm at work, when they're tired. By day five they've brought a snack, and the urge has shrunk. The lesson isn't about the week. It's about the trigger.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

A clearer sense of your triggers and habits, and often a reset of your defaults. Some people also find spending less than usual surprisingly easy once they've paused.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating it as a test of willpower or starting it in a week that's guaranteed to fail. Design it to be doable. If you break it, note why, and continue. Never skip essentials like food, health or bills.

TRY THIS TODAY

Choose your start date and write your "allowed" list on the next page now.

ALLOWED

- Essential food
- Housing
- Transport
- Medication and health necessities
- Required bills

My optional categories (you decide)

YOUR SEVEN DAYS

DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5	DAY 6	DAY 7
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Urges I noticed, and what triggered them

What I missed, and what I didn't

MONEY HACK

#15

The 30-Day Purchase List

Let time decide which wants deserve your money.

THE PROBLEM

A wish appears, and you either buy it immediately or feel deprived when you don't. Either way, the wish takes up space in your head, and often in your wardrobe.

WHY WE DO IT

Wants come in waves. When a wave hits, it feels permanent. When it passes, what remains is either a real preference or nothing at all.

THE HACK

Keep a **30-day purchase list.** Instead of buying a non-essential item, write it down with the date, the price and why you want it. Thirty days later, ask: *do I still want it?* Time acts as a filter, and what survives can be bought with confidence.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Your list becomes a map of your real desires, and a surprisingly effective way to shop less without feeling deprived.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep the list somewhere handy: a notes app, a spreadsheet or the worksheet on the next page.
2. Add an item the moment you want it, with the date, the price and a one-line reason.
3. Set a reminder for 30 days later.
4. When the date arrives, honestly answer: still want it? Would I choose it over other uses of the money?
5. Buy what passes the test (Hack #8 can help). Cross out what doesn't, and enjoy the money you kept.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU ADD TO THE LIST**
> Do I want this, or the feeling it promises? Where would it live in my home? What else could this money do?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical list after a month: a €60 kitchen gadget (no longer wanted), a €35 book (still wanted, bought), a €120 jacket (already had similar, crossed out), and a €45 plant pot (still wanted, bought). Two purchases made, two avoided, all decided calmly.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Fewer impulse buys, and more satisfaction from the things you do buy, because they've been chosen. It also builds patience without banning anything.

COMMON MISTAKE

Letting the list become a shopping wishlist you feel obliged to complete. It isn't a to-buy list. Crossing items off is the success, not buying them. Don't forget to review on the date.

TRY THIS TODAY

Add the last non-essential thing you wanted to the list, with today's date.

YOUR 30-DAY PURCHASE LIST

DATE ADDED	ITEM	PRICE (€)	WHY I WANT IT	STILL WANT IT AFTER 30 DAYS? (Y / N)

MONEY HACK

#16

Stop Lifestyle Creep

Let your raise improve your life, not just your baseline.



THE PROBLEM

You get a raise, a new job or a bonus. Within months, the extra income is absorbed by a bigger flat, nicer dinners, more subscriptions. Your income has grown, but your savings haven't.

WHY WE DO IT

Spending adapts upwards quickly and painlessly, and what felt luxurious becomes normal. We compare ourselves to people around us, and each new level resets the meaning of "enough."

THE HACK

Decide in advance how any increase in income will be divided. **Income increases → spending increases → savings unchanged** is the default. **The Raise Rule** replaces it: split each increase between **savings, debt reduction, goals and lifestyle improvements.** You still get to enjoy it. You just decide how.

MONEY HACK
Give every raise a job before it arrives. Enjoy a share of it, and let the rest work for you.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Work out the extra net income: the change in what actually lands in your account.
2. Choose your split. There's no standard formula. One example is on the next page.
3. Set up the automatic transfers for the savings and debt shares first.
4. Spend the lifestyle share intentionally, on something you'll notice and enjoy.
5. Revisit the split after a few months, and after any major life change.

THINK BEFORE YOU UPGRADE YOUR LIFE
Will this new cost repeat every month? Would I still choose it if my income dipped? Is it a one-off or a new fixed cost?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

Imagine a hypothetical raise that adds €200 a month after tax. One possible split: 40% (€80) to savings, 20% (€40) to debt reduction, 20% (€40) to a goal such as a trip, and 20% (€40) for lifestyle. Your income rose, your savings rose, and your life got a little nicer too.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Progress on savings and goals, even as your lifestyle improves. Because the decision happens before the money arrives, there's less to resist later.

COMMON MISTAKE

Assigning 100% to "future you" and then abandoning the whole thing. A share for lifestyle keeps it sustainable. Also, don't wait for the raise. A small change works with any increase, including a cheaper bill.

TRY THIS TODAY

Write down your default split for the next raise, bonus or refund. Put it where you'll find it.

AN EXAMPLE SPLIT (ILLUSTRATIVE)



On a hypothetical increase of €200 a month, this split is €80, €40, €40 and €40.

YOUR RAISE RULE

	SAVINGS	DEBT REDUCTION	GOALS	LIFESTYLE
Share of the increase (%)				
Amount per month (€)				

My next increase (€ per month)

Date I'll apply the rule

HYPOTHETICAL CASE STUDY

Priya and the raise that vanished

Priya gets a raise and moves into a nicer flat. A year later, her savings look much as they did before. When her next raise arrives, she splits it *before* it lands in her account: part to savings, part to debt, part to a trip she's planning, and part to enjoy. Her lifestyle still improves. Just not all of it.

Fictional and illustrative. Individual results vary, and none is guaranteed.

MONEY HACK

#17

Spend Money Where It Matters

Financial intelligence isn't spending less. It's spending on purpose.

THE PROBLEM

After sixteen hacks, there's a risk: you become someone who only cuts. Cutting without direction can leave a life that's tidier, but no happier. The point of saving was never the saving itself.

WHY WE DO IT

Most of us spend by inheritance: on what our habits, friends, marketing and defaults suggest, not on what we've decided matters. Spending well requires knowing what matters.

THE HACK

Map your values to your spending. **The Personal Value Map** groups life into eight areas: **health, relationships, experiences, time, security, learning, comfort and fun.** For each, note what you spend on now, and rate honestly how much it improves your life. Then move money toward what matters, and away from what doesn't.

> **MONEY HACK**
> Spend on what matters. Cut what doesn't. The second half of that sentence only works with the first.

HOW TO DO IT

1. Look at your last month of spending. List your ten biggest discretionary items.
2. Place each item in the value area it serves best, or note if it fits none.
3. Rate each area from 1 to 5 for how much your current spending improves your life.
4. Look for gaps (areas you value but under-fund) and for surplus (spending with no clear value).
5. Choose one shift to make this month: a little less here, a little more there.

> **THINK BEFORE YOU SPEND**
> Whose expectations am I spending on? What did I enjoy most last month? What would future me thank me for?

EXAMPLE · HYPOTHETICAL

A hypothetical reader notices they spend a lot on takeaway (fun? comfort?) but little on seeing friends (relationships), which they rate as their top priority. They cut two takeaways and replace them with a monthly dinner with friends. Total spending barely changes. The value of the money rises sharply.

POTENTIAL BENEFIT

Spending that matches your priorities, which is often more satisfying than spending simply less. It can also help with big decisions about where your money should go.

COMMON MISTAKE

Filling the map with what you think you *should* value. Be honest. If fun matters to you, that's not a flaw. Your map is yours alone.

TRY THIS TODAY

Answer the three questions on the next page in one sitting. Trust your first answers.

YOUR PERSONAL VALUE MAP

HEALTH
Body, mind, medical care, rest
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

RELATIONSHIPS
Family, partner, friends, community
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

EXPERIENCES
Travel, events, memories made
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

TIME
Anything that buys back hours
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

SECURITY
Savings, insurance, stability
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

LEARNING
Skills, books, courses
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

COMFORT
Home, sleep, everyday ease
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

FUN
Play, hobbies, pure enjoyment
Worth it? (1–5) ○○○○○

What purchases genuinely improve my life?

What spending could disappear without affecting my happiness?

What do I want my money to make possible?

PART TWO

How to spend money wisely

One decision system for every purchase.

Saving is half the story. The other half is deciding, calmly and consistently, what is worth buying at all.

The 17 hacks give you individual tools. This part joins them into one **decision-making system** you can use in ten seconds at the till, or ten minutes before a big purchase. Think of it as a filter: everything you're about to buy passes through eight questions, and whatever comes out the other side is something you can buy with a clear conscience.

It's a conversation with yourself, not a calculator. One "no" doesn't necessarily mean stop, but the more red flags you notice, the more reason to wait.



THE SMART SPENDING FILTER

#	The question	Why it matters	Red-flag answer
1	Do I need it?	Separates real needs from wants	"Not really"
2	Do I already own something similar?	Stops duplicates	"Yes, kind of"
3	Can I afford it without using debt?	Protects your future self	"Only on credit"
4	Have I compared alternatives?	Prevents first-option buying	"No, it was the first I saw"
5	Will I use it regularly?	Tests cost per use	"Occasionally, maybe"
6	Is the quality appropriate?	Avoids paying for too little or too much	"Not sure what I'm paying for"
7	Am I buying because I want it, or because I feel pressured?	Spots urgency, FOMO and social pressure	"There's a countdown"
8	Does it support my priorities?	Ties spending to your Value Map	"It fits nothing I care about"

HOW TO READ YOUR ANSWERS

- **Mostly yes, no red flags:** buy it, guilt-free.
- **One or two red flags:** wait 24 hours (Hack #2) and ask again.
- **Three or more, or Question 3 is a red flag:** put it on your 30-Day Purchase List (Hack #15) and let time decide.

PRINTABLE · ONE PAGE

The Smart Spending Filter

Print this page and keep a few copies. Or use the fillable fields on screen. A decision made on paper is a decision made on purpose.

Item I'm considering

Price (€)

Date

THE EIGHT QUESTIONS	YES	NO	NOT SURE
1 Do I need it? Red flag: Not really	☐	☐	☐
2 Do I already own something similar? Red flag: Yes, kind of	☐	☐	☐
3 Can I afford it without using debt? Red flag: Only on credit	☐	☐	☐
4 Have I compared alternatives? Red flag: No, it was the first I saw	☐	☐	☐
5 Will I use it regularly? Red flag: Occasionally, maybe	☐	☐	☐
6 Is the quality appropriate? Red flag: Not sure what I'm paying for	☐	☐	☐
7 Am I buying because I want it, or because I feel pressured? Red flag: There's a countdown	☐	☐	☐
8 Does it support my priorities? Red flag: It fits nothing I care about	☐	☐	☐

MY DECISION ☐ Buy it, guilt-free ☐ Wait 24 hours ☐ Park it on my 30-day list ☐ Skip it

Notes: what did this filter tell me?

SPENDING UNDER PRESSURE

Seven pressure tactics to spot

Tick any you notice. Naming a tactic is often enough to weaken it.

- [ ] "Only a few left!" or a countdown clock
- [ ] "Free shipping" if you add one more item
- [ ] "Buy now, pay later" for something you couldn't otherwise afford
- [ ] A "was €99, now €59" price you never saw at €99
- [ ] A friend, influencer or salesperson who benefits from your yes
- [ ] A bundle that includes things you didn't plan to buy
- [ ] Feeling bad, bored or left out when the urge shows up

THE FILTER IN ACTION (HYPOTHETICAL)

Situation (hypothetical)	Filter says…	Likely decision
A 50%-off sale on shoes. You own four similar pairs.	Q2 red flag; Q1 not really; Q7 pressure	Skip, or list it and wait 30 days
The washing machine breaks. Two models in your range.	Need yes; Q3 fine; Q4 compare three (Hack #12)	Buy after a short comparison
Your friend group is booking a €300 weekend away.	Q8 relationships high; Q3 needs checking	Say yes if it's in your fun or experience budget. If not, suggest a cheaper plan.

A WORD ON "BUY NOW, PAY LATER"

If the only way you can afford it is by borrowing, that is your answer to Question 3, not an obstacle to work around. Borrowing for a genuine need can be reasonable. Borrowing for a want deserves a very long pause.

TRY THIS TODAY

Print the one-page filter and keep it where you shop online. Use it on the next non-essential purchase you're tempted by.

PART THREE

Build your personal money system

The 5-Bucket Money System.

A money system is simply a set of decisions made once, so you don't have to remake them every day.

Your money has six jobs: paying for **essentials,** building **savings,** moving toward **goals,** meeting **debt obligations,** funding everyday **lifestyle** and providing **fun money.** Juggling six is tiring, so this system folds them into five buckets. Goals share the savings bucket as named sub-pots (a trip, a course, a deposit).

Every payday, income is divided among the buckets, and each bucket has its own rules. When a bucket is empty, that's information rather than failure.

Bucket	What belongs here	The rule
1 Essentials	Housing, food, utilities, transport, health, insurance	Pay first. Review annually (Hack #7)
2 Savings & goals	Emergency fund, and named pots for goals	Automate on payday (Hacks #10, #11)
3 Debt	Repayments beyond what's counted in Essentials	Automate. Extra payments count as progress
4 Lifestyle	Everyday flexible spending: clothes, home, eating out	Use the filter (Part Two)
5 Fun money	The guilt-free account	Spend freely. When it's gone, it's gone (Hack #9)

SAMPLE HYPOTHETICAL BUDGETS: PERCENTAGES ARE EXAMPLES, NOT RULES.

Monthly take-home €2,400 · a balanced month



Monthly take-home €2,400 · a month with high rent



THE NUMBERS

Bucket	Balanced month	€	High-rent month	€
Essentials	50%	€1,200	65%	€1,560
Savings & goals	15%	€360	10%	€240
Debt	10%	€240	5%	€120
Lifestyle	15%	€360	12%	€288
Fun money	10%	€240	8%	€192
Total	100%	€2,400	100%	€2,400

MAKE IT YOURS

There's no universal split. Your percentages should reflect your housing costs, your debts, your goals and your stage of life. A student, a parent and a freelancer will all build different systems. Start with what's true now, then adjust one bucket at a time.

YOUR 5-BUCKET WORKSHEET

My monthly take-home (€)

Month

BUCKET	SHARE OF TAKE-HOME (%)	AMOUNT (€)	MY RULE FOR THIS BUCKET
1 Essentials			
2 Savings & goals			
3 Debt			
4 Lifestyle			
5 Fun money			
Total (aim for 100%)			

YOUR WEEKLY TEN-MINUTE CHECK-IN

- [ ] Check the balance in each bucket (five minutes)
- [ ] Note anything that surprised you
- [ ] Move any leftover Lifestyle money to Savings, or roll it over, on purpose
- [ ] Look ahead: any bills or events in the next two weeks?

Your AI money assistant

A helpful tool, never a replacement for your judgement.



AI tools can be a patient assistant for the boring parts of money management. They're not a financial advisor, and they shouldn't be your judgement.

WHAT AI CAN HELP WITH

- **Categorise** anonymised expenses into Essentials, Lifestyle, Impulse and so on
- **Compare** spending patterns between months
- **Identify** likely recurring payments in a list
- **Build** meal plans and shopping lists around a budget
- **Draft** budget spreadsheets and formulas
- **Plan** savings goals and timelines
- **Generate questions** to ask yourself before a purchase or when reviewing a month

WHAT IT CAN'T DO

- AI can make mistakes, including in arithmetic. **Check any numbers yourself.**
- It doesn't know your full situation, your country's rules or your values.
- It can't replace a qualified professional for tax, legal or investment questions.
- Treat every answer as a draft to review, not an instruction to follow.

PRIVACY FIRST: KEEP IT ANONYMOUS

- **Never** paste passwords, PINs, banking logins, one-time codes or security answers
- **Never** share full account, IBAN or card numbers, or ID and tax numbers
- Remove names, addresses and anything that could identify you or others
- Use rounded amounts and general labels ("Streaming, €12") rather than raw statements
- Check the tool's privacy settings and what it does with your data

THREE HABITS FOR BETTER ANSWERS

Give context, not credentials. Describe your situation in general terms. **Ask for questions first.** A good assistant asks before advising. **Ask it to show its working,** then check the numbers yourself.

TEN PRACTICAL PROMPTS

Copy, fill in the [brackets], and stay anonymous

01 — Categorise

Analyze this anonymized monthly spending list and group the expenses into categories: Essentials, Lifestyle, Impulse, Subscriptions, Debt and Other. Show the total for each category.

02 — Plan groceries

Help me create a realistic grocery plan for one week for [number] people on a budget of €[amount]. Include a shopping list grouped by store section and use leftovers wisely.

03 — Annualise

Turn these recurring expenses into monthly and annual costs, and list them from highest annual cost to lowest: [list of expenses with monthly prices].

04 — Compare months

Here are my anonymized expenses for two months, grouped by category. Point out the three biggest changes and ask me questions before suggesting anything.

05 — Build a spreadsheet

Design a simple monthly budget spreadsheet with five buckets (Essentials, Savings & goals, Debt, Lifestyle, Fun money) that calculates each bucket's amount from a net income of €[amount]. Show the formulas.

06 — Spot recurring costs

From this anonymized list of transactions (no account numbers), which look like recurring payments? List them with an estimated frequency and yearly cost, and mark anything I should check.

07 — Question a purchase

I'm thinking of buying [item] for €[price]. Ask me these eight questions one at a time: [the Smart Spending Filter]. At the end, summarise my answers and point out any red flags.

08 — Plan a savings goal

Help me plan how to save €[goal] in [number] months. Show weekly milestones and what happens if I miss a month. Keep it realistic and don't assume my income will rise.

09 — Draft a bill call

Write a short, polite script for contacting my [internet/phone] provider to ask whether my €[amount] monthly plan can be reduced, and list three follow-up questions.

10 — Check my values

Here are my personal value areas and my rough monthly spending in each. Ask me five questions to help me see whether my spending matches what matters to me. Don't give investment advice.

PART FOUR

The 30-day money makeover

Small daily steps. A system that lasts.

Thirty days, five to fifteen minutes a day. Each day has one **task,** one **question,** one **action** and one **reflection.** Miss a day? Carry on with the next one. Progress beats perfection.

WEEK 1 · AWARENESS — See where your money actually goes.

DAY	TASK	QUESTION	ACTION	REFLECTION	DONE
1	Take a money snapshot	Do I roughly know what's in my accounts right now?	Write down your balances and next payday.	*How did it feel to look?*	☐
2	Start your 7-Day Reset (Hack #1)	What will I capture, and where?	Create your "Reset Week" note. Log today.	*What did I notice about my first purchase?*	☐
3	Keep tracking, every purchase	Which purchases were planned, which unplanned?	Mark each entry Essential, Lifestyle or Impulse.	*Which purchase felt automatic?*	☐
4	Gather three months of statements	What repeats each month?	Highlight every recurring charge.	*Which one had I forgotten?*	☐
5	Do the Subscription Audit (Hack #3)	Would I sign up for each today?	Fill in the audit. Mark Keep, Cancel or Review.	*Which item surprised me?*	☐
6	Finish your Reset Week	What surprised me most?	Total each column. Circle the biggest one.	*What does this say about my habits?*	☐
7	Use the Annual Cost lens (Hack #13)	Which annual number surprised me?	Complete the calculator for five recurring costs.	*What am I glad to keep paying for?*	☐

WEEK 2 · CUTTING FINANCIAL LEAKAGE — Trim what doesn't earn its place.

DAY	TASK	QUESTION	ACTION	REFLECTION	DONE
8	Cancel what you marked Cancel	What will I do with the saving?	Cancel at least one item and note the yearly saving.	*How did it feel to let go?*	☐
9	Pick one bill to review (Hack #7)	What would a fair comparison look like?	Find one alternative and note its price.	*Do I feel ready to ask?*	☐
10	Make the call or send the message	What do I want: a lower price, a better plan or clarity?	Ask the three questions. Note the answer.	*What did I learn, even if the answer was no?*	☐
11	Audit your convenience spending (Hack #5)	Which extra charges bought real value?	Mark each as valuable convenience or habit.	*Which habit is easiest to change?*	☐
12	Plan the week's groceries (Hack #6)	What's already in my fridge?	Write 4 to 5 meals and a shopping list.	*How did planning feel?*	☐
13	Shop with your list	Will I use everything I'm buying?	Stick to the list. Compare unit prices.	*What tempted me, and why?*	☐
14	Review Week 2	What is my running total of yearly savings?	Write the total. Decide where it will go.	*What was hardest this week?*	☐

WEEK 3 · BUILDING BETTER HABITS — Put a pause between wanting and buying.					
DAY	**TASK**	**QUESTION**	**ACTION**	**REFLECTION**	**DONE**
15	Adopt the 24-Hour Rule (Hack #2)	What is my threshold?	Write it down and apply it to your next purchase.	*Did the urge fade?*	☐
16	Start the 30-Day Purchase List (Hack #15)	What have I wanted lately?	Add three items with today's date.	*Are any already fading?*	☐
17	Use Need / Want / Value (Hack #8)	Does it provide enough value for its cost?	Fill in the worksheet for one purchase.	*Did the answer change my mind?*	☐
18	Set your Fun Money (Hack #9)	How much can I sustain?	Choose the amount and where it lives.	*What am I looking forward to?*	☐
19	Run the Price-Per-Use test (Hack #4)	How many times will I honestly use it?	Calculate the cost per use.	*Would I decide differently?*	☐
20	Compare three (Hack #12)	What do I actually need it to do?	Fill in the comparison for a planned purchase.	*Was the cheapest the best?*	☐
21	Review Week 3	Which habit feels easiest to keep?	Choose two habits to keep going.	*Where did I feel most in control?*	☐

WEEK 4 · CREATING A SUSTAINABLE MONEY SYSTEM — Turn habits into a system that runs itself.					
DAY	**TASK**	**QUESTION**	**ACTION**	**REFLECTION**	**DONE**
22	Begin the No-Spend Challenge (Hack #14)	What's allowed, and what isn't?	Write your rules and tell someone.	*What urge showed up first?*	☐
23	No-spend day 2. Automate savings (Hack #10)	What amount can I keep up?	Schedule a transfer for the day after payday.	*How does it feel to decide once?*	☐
24	No-spend day 3. Start an emergency fund (Hack #11)	What are my essential monthly costs?	Set your first target and name the account.	*What would this cushion give me?*	☐
25	No-spend day 4. Value Map (Hack #17)	What do I want my money to make possible?	Fill in the Personal Value Map.	*What is the gap between values and spending?*	☐
26	No-spend day 5. The Raise Rule (Hack #16)	How will I divide my next increase?	Write your split, even for a small windfall.	*What would future me thank me for?*	☐
27	No-spend day 6. Build your 5 buckets	What do my real percentages look like?	Complete the 5-Bucket worksheet.	*Which bucket needs the most attention?*	☐
28	No-spend day 7. Review the challenge	What did I miss, and what didn't I?	Note three things you'll keep.	*What surprised me about my habits?*	☐
29	Do your first Monthly Money Review	What's working, and what isn't?	Complete the review page.	*What is one adjustment for next month?*	☐
30	Design your routine and celebrate	Which three habits will I keep?	Pick a monthly review date. Put it in your calendar.	*What am I proud of?*	☐

THE FINISH LINE

Two checkpoints and a scorecard

TWO CHECKPOINTS

Halfway check (Day 15): Am I still tracking, cancelling or asking? If not, go easy on yourself and pick up wherever you are. **Finish line (Day 30):** Write down three things you now know about your money that you didn't know a month ago.

YOUR DAY-30 SCORECARD

- [ ] I know roughly where my money goes each month
- [ ] I've cancelled or reviewed at least one recurring cost
- [ ] I use a pause (24 hours or 30 days) before non-essential purchases
- [ ] I have a fun-money amount I can spend guilt-free
- [ ] My savings transfer runs automatically
- [ ] I've started an emergency fund, however small
- [ ] I know what I want my money to make possible
- [ ] I've put my Monthly Money Review in my calendar

Three things I now know about my money that I didn't know 30 days ago

WORKSHEET · USE IT EVERY MONTH

Your Monthly Money Review

Once a month, ideally the same day, sit down for twenty minutes. Look, learn, adjust, and then close the book.

Month

Take-home this month (€)

Date of review

BUCKET	PLANNED (€)	ACTUAL (€)	DIFFERENCE (€)
Essentials			
Savings & goals			
Debt			
Lifestyle			
Fun money			

Wins this month

One adjustment for next month

Leaks I noticed

How in control did I feel? (1–5) and why

CHECKLIST

- [ ] I checked my subscriptions and recurring bills
- [ ] My automatic transfers ran as planned
- [ ] I reviewed my 30-Day Purchase List
- [ ] I checked my emergency fund progress
- [ ] I decided what to change next month

— THE LAST PAGE

Your money, your choices.

You don't need to control every cent.

You need to know where your money is going, and make intentional choices about where it should go.

Somewhere in these pages you probably found a number that surprised you: a subscription you'd forgotten, a habit that costs more than it gives, a small change that can quietly work for you every month. That's the whole idea. Not perfection. Not deprivation. Just attention, and a few good decisions repeated.

Money is not only about accumulation. It's a tool. It can buy **security** on a bad day, **freedom** to say no, **experiences** worth remembering, **time** with the people you love, **opportunity** when it appears and the very quiet luxury of **peace of mind.**

So keep what you've earned. Spend on what matters. Let the rest go without guilt. And remember: the goal was never a spreadsheet. It was a life that feels like yours.

SAVE SMARTER.
SPEND WITH PURPOSE.
KEEP MORE.
LIVE BETTER.